

pray
ers
for
a rott
en
seed

feed your boy good & plenty

you want to be worshiped but you don't like the height
of the pedestal i built you
said i spent too much on the materials
said how am i supposed to act up here
said more importantly how am i supposed to get down

i felt you kept me at a distance
i felt the distance

i begged for you to open the lock, to let me bring you
an offering
to feed your belly good & plenty, even though i always
left hungry and poor

i do not blame you for hiding the keys
for swallowing them, repeatedly
kept me close, kept them closer
i do not blame myself for wearing you out with dance,
for distracting you with song, for digging holes to reach
you as you slept in my arms

i understand why you bought the concrete, invited me
over to help you lay it down. i came willingly, like you
knew i would. i'm aware enough to admit you need
protecting and strong enough to help you build

i do not blame myself for climbing the fence, for never
being scared of heights
you wanted me to be scared of heights, to admit that i
don't know how to fly
and that taking you with me meant the clipping of
your wings, meant the removal of your vocal cords,
meant drowning you in whatever wave i am today

watering tight spaces

i hate missing you
hate thinking about how we share a laugh
that we dance the same
hate that my roots still speak to yours
hate that you still need my sweet water
hate that i still want to feed you
are you okay?
don't answer that

why am i asking if my heart is ready to be broken
by you again?

why can i feel your fingers pressed into my
ventricles?
you cut off all of my air
my precious blood
never spilled
only offered
only for you

honey boy

i don't know how to man
don't know how to spend \$250 on shoes
don't know the make and model, when they came
out, what the resale value is
don't know when to dap
or when to hug
don't know why some men are so scared of hugging
of talking about their mothers
of dreaming about holding their daughters

don't know how to not cross the street when
mother and child are walking my way, when a
woman is walking alone
don't know if i should nod head up or head down
don't know which one is a threat and which one is a
greeting
i don't know why i would ever want to to come off
as a threat
i don't know how to show my strength
never learned how to shoot a gun, to kill an animal

what i do know
is how to carry little pocket knives
how to cut flowers and tie them into bouquets for
my lover

what i do know is that these are stereotypes
that not all men fit into these boxes

i'm only trying to express how they pick me out
that i don't know how to speak up
how to take up space
how to uncross my legs

Mars Bars

remember when i told you i was raised by sea
people
well, they left me on a dial tone
so i'm wondering if i could crash pad on your
petals for the past week
or maybe just the next 3 days
i know when it rains it hoards

so i've been wearing these assless chaps which left
me in a rug burn
and i'm in flames

convinced myself my future already happened so
when i fell asleep i woke up fast

11 years later and i'm still learning
that things happen when you always expect them

so i admit
i've been writing the letters
of your name in the seams

because i was hooked on sonic
because fast food
comes at you fast
so i never learned how to read
never learned how to breathe or is it breath
either way it's the last quarter i have left

so if you could please connect me to the operator
please give me number 9
and if you disconnect me

i never fall this far behind
when i'm running sideways
in front of the pack

don't look left
because the back of your hands
are maps and i am lost in the transatlantic

saw tumbling seaweed but i couldn't catch it
without a light

so yes
i am stone cold steve austin
3:16 year olds discovered a comet while looking in
a telescope

so you can't blame me for naming rocks and
bringing them home
for making them dance
for wishing i didn't have sticky fingers
for getting lost in the milky way

traditions ≥

my parents' restaurant, also called childcare, the hospital, home. sick days weren't spent sick. would've inhaled the dirt through a straw if it would've made cleaning the carpets faster. we had a manual vacuum. it actually worked pretty decent.

when the seasons started beating my parents home, i questioned if the restaurant was more like a prison. how can you feed strangers? can't you see i'm going hungry?

food in the house of a restaurant owner is usually bread and cheese, sometimes a few cans of something that never expires, but it's never as much as people believe it is.

one night, after my father came home from work, he woke me from sleep, carried me to the kitchen counter, and we took turns eating the stale halloween candy my parents had collected from us to redistribute in our lunches.

in that moment, i felt chosen.

religion

when the third sibling on my father's side died of diabetes, the sweet tooth in our mouths became coffins.

i do not share land or language with my ancestors,
hardly share a last name.

history is sometimes twisted neatly into parts of
you,

and you can suck them down trying to dissolve,
but i am from their ocean,
sugar in my veins and all.

parents apparently don't know how to parent,
teaching bad habits like a religion.

i guess technically the rot in my mouth will bring
me closer to the state of god.

but what if i'm not ready to sacrifice more of
myself, not ready to pass traditions?

maybe i don't want to share the sickness.
have we thought about future mutations?

it's in our blood.

dress for the job you want

i don't want a job

i want to drive around a small town drinking
mountain dew and chain smoking cigarettes,
stopping to pee in gas stations and to eat take-out
on the curb

i want to search my car for loose coins, even
though the cashier at the corner store would never
charge me because we all have what we need

i want to work in the garden with the hours of the
sun

i want to rest when my body asks for it

fill when i am depleted

deplete when i am overflowing

water the seeds in my pocket

and grow the dreams i keep losing when i'm
sleepless

tossing and turning

trying to conjure that one invention that will

uproot me from this nightmare

i mean, from this american dream

exodus from the family nest

foreign kids don't leave quietly
don't leave with blessings or helping hands.
we leave in bits and pieces, packed bags in the
middle of the night.
we leave kicking and screaming, fingers pointed at
each other, at gods, at ourselves.
we leave with mothers taking fathers' sides, no
matter how many promises she made behind his
back.
we leave spitting words and blood, nailing grudges
to door frames, kissing them on the way out.

foreign parents don't come to your apartment,
don't bring you a housewarming gift.
they call to ask why you haven't been home lately.
why you don't call.
they want to know where you've been,
how long you stayed,
who's been over.
wants to keep keeping tabs.
says they care.
says they're worried about you.
says you're eating too much.
says you're not eating enough.
says your picture on facebook changed, why is
there a person in the background drinking?
says were you at a party?
says do you drink?

says are you high right now?
says do you ever get nervous?
they don't say that.
they ask if it's their fault, and in a way it is.

foreign parents teach you how to rise
how to make food from the ashes
how to remove our limbs so we can be everywhere
at once, even though foreign parents will never be
at your recitals, or open mics,
the same way i don't want to be on the couch
watching dad's sport ball games.
don't want to work foreign parents' 14 hour shifts,
don't want to put myself second to anyone,
don't want to share my bank account.

foreign parents teach you how to save.
teach you how to dance for rainy days,
how to collect the water in containers my mother
has been saving for an occasion just like this.

ima lets me grocery shop in her fridge,
she knows i don't know how to budget,
knows i don't know how to hold up all the walls
i've built, all the bridges i've burned.
don't know what to do with the pieces i've been
collecting, the ones still burning, the promises, the
knots i've untied.

ima knows i don't have all the recipes.
foreign parents don't write down the recipes.
don't measure out the family traumas,
it's passed down genetically, or by osmosis, but
probably both and also neither.

maybe it's from sitting in the kitchen where all of
the gossip is. learned my foreign parents'
mannerisms, like
when i correct my partner on how to hold a paring
knife,
or question them on why the fire is on so high,
what spices they used,
i say it's too much.
i say it's not enough.
i say i don't like wasting water.
but what i'm really saying is,
foreign parents measure how much water you use
so they can correct you when you're doing their
chores.
they say it'll teach you how to keep house one day,
teach you how to respect the resources we know
will run out.
foreign parents say my parents did it this way
and their parents did it this way, so it must be
done.

foreign parents want you to go, want you to stay.
want a happiness for you that only exists in the
fairytales they read. foreign parents want you to
run, but never as far as they did.

soft stone

remember that time i drove to canada alone
ate nothing but roadside apples and honey
drank nothing but gas station coffee
told myself

 this isn't depression
at least, not the depression i know

i held rocks in my fists till they crystallized
gave them as gifts when i returned
prayed i softened their edges
prayed i could soften my own
i thanked them for teaching me lessons
for leaving scars
for choosing me

i'm thankful for time zones
that i got one hour of that day back as i crossed
state lines
or maybe i lost it
either way, it feels like a victory
like a second chance
like i'm not going to take advantage of it
like i'm not going to leave the broken alone

dancing with clowns

i see things that remind me of you and have to
pretend like you don't exist
like this scary clown wouldn't bring you joy
that i don't want to hold your hand
or kiss your cheek
get a little too drunk
dance like everyone is watching
and make out
a little
just a little

maybe that's where we went wrong
blurred the lines
started to blend
i thought we melted together nicely
but maybe i'm naive
and a little too tender
too young in the head
too loose with my heart

